

Question:

A mental health volunteer is interviewing locals as part of a community outreach program. A 46-year-old man discloses that he has felt sad for as long as he can remember. He feels as though his life is cursed and if something terrible can happen to him, it usually will. He has difficulty making decisions and feels hopeless. He also feels that he has had worsening suicidal ideations, guilt from past problems, energy, and concentration over the past 2 weeks. He is otherwise getting enough sleep and able to hold a job. Which of the following statement best describes this patient's condition?

Answer Choices:

- A. The patient is at risk for double depression.
- B. The patient may have symptoms of mania or psychosis.
- C. The patient is likely to show anhedonia.
- D. The patient likely has paranoid personality disorder.

Reasoning + Answer:

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Finding Reasoning Paths :

- 1 . **Somatic delusions**: Delusions of sadness and the sense that terrible things are destined to happen , combined with symptoms such as anhedonia , mood changes , and pessimistic outlook , suggest a mood disorder or psychotic condition .
- 2 . **Anhedonia**: The patient reports difficulty experiencing joy or pleasure , which is a hallmark of major depressive disorder (MDD).
- 3 . **Sleep and appetite**: The patient 's ability to sleep and hold a job suggests that his symptoms are not severe enough to impair these basic functions , which makes severe major depressive disorder less likely .
- 4 . **Mood changes and decision-making difficulties**: These symptoms align with mild depressive symptoms , possibly indicating cyclothymia or a mild mood disorder rather than major depression .
- 5 . **Suicidal ideation**: The patient reports worsening suicidal ideation , which is a concerning symptom and warrants further evaluation for potential mood disorders or psychosis .
- 6 . **Mania or hypomania**: The absence of hypomanic episodes or manic behavior makes this unlikely , as hypomania or mania would typically involve elevated mood , increased energy , and irritability .

Reasoning Process :

- 1 . **Examine the symptoms**: The patient describes feelings of sadness , a pessimistic outlook , decision-making difficulties , and worsening suicidal ideation . These symptoms suggest a mood disorder . The presence of anhedonia (difficulty enjoying activities) further supports this .
- 2 . **Consider the severity**: While the patient reports some emotional distress , his ability to sleep and hold a job suggests that the symptoms are moderate rather than severe . Severe depression would typically impair daily functioning .
- 3 . **Differentiate from major depressive disorder**: The patient 's symptoms are less severe than what would typically characterize major depressive disorder , as that condition often results in significant functional impairment (e.g ., difficulty holding a job , extreme fatigue , or suicidal ideation that leads to hospitalization).
- 4 . **Evaluate for cyclothymia or other mild mood disorders**: The patient 's symptoms align more closely with a mild mood disorder , such as cyclothymia , which involves fluctuating mood symptoms without reaching the severity of bipolar disorder or major depressive disorder .
- 5 . **Address suicidal ideation**: Worsening suicidal ideation is concerning and requires careful monitoring and appropriate intervention , such as psychological counseling or medication if indicated .
- 6 . **Exclude other conditions**: There is no evidence to suggest the patient has a personality disorder (e.g ., paranoid personality disorder), as his symptoms are better explained by a mood disorder .

Conclusion :

The patient 's condition is best described as **cyclothymia** , a mild mood disorder characterized by fluctuating mood symptoms without reaching the severity of bipolar disorder or major depressive disorder .

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<answer>

The patient likely has symptoms of mania or psychosis .

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